We left our peace stations in March and moved by road and rail to the exercise area in Rajasthan. The role of the corps is such that we have to acquire the capability of moving across the breadth of the country rapidly and by different means of transportation. In our case some units and formations had to cover about 1400 kilometres to gather for the exercise. We were able to rustle up 80–90 per cent of the posted strength so that this war-like experience was of benefit to maximum officers and men. It was also a good opportunity to assess the knowledge, capabilities and leadership qualities of the higher commanders as well as of the junior leaders. During such manoeuvres, one could identify the professionally sound or unfit individuals, sub units and units; an experienced eye could easily gauge the state of morale and motivation of men and the units as a whole.

In this joint army-air offensive exercise, we had planned to try out new concepts, strategy and tactics. These included use of high technology, employment of UAVs and sensors, exploitation of enhanced night fighting capabilities, IT, information warfare, joint operations and fighting through a nuclear environment. Air power and army aviation assets were effectively enmeshed as war-winning factors and their capabilities optimally showcased. For the first time, we tried out the concept of a mobile forward surgical centre – an 'operation theatre on wheels'. This was achieved by joining four air-conditioned vehicles and connecting them with an airtight passage to make this facility dustproof and air-conditioned. This was located next to the field hospital. We also fielded a nuclear, biological and chemical (NBC) warfare shelter and a decontamination unit.

Being an important exercise, and also because of the hype created by the media, we had many visitors and observers during various phases of this event. In fact, the presence of the defence minister, Jaswant Singh, the army chief, General S. Padmanabhan, Air Chief Marshal A.Y. Tipnis and other army, air force and naval higher commanders was morale boosting. The presence of defence attachés of friendly countries, and a host of mediapersons, including those from the BBC and CNN, heightened the profile of the manoeuvres even further. Often, these visitors were the cause of avoidable